

Why circular economy must be India's response to the rising threat of e-waste

Circular economy, focused on reusing, recycling and repurposing materials, **can** create jobs and build a **sustainable** future

Studies by the United Nations **show** that roughly 2.01 billion tonnes of waste is produced globally every year. India is no exception to this major waste crisis.

India is the third largest producer of e-waste in the world. In 2023-24, the country generated 1.751 million metric tonnes of e-waste, which is an **alarming** 72.54 per cent increase from 2019-20. The question we are now faced with is - how do we fix this? The answer **lies** in circular economy, a smarter way of thinking about waste.

Rather than the ongoing 'use and throw' approach that we practise today, circular economy places its focus on 'reusing, recycling and repurposing' materials as far as possible. **Opting** for a circular economy **can** have **manifold** benefits for us, including reduced pollution, new employment opportunities, and a healthier, sustainable future.

In our dynamic digital world, consumers are purchasing gadgets at an **unprecedented** rate. But what happens when these devices become **obsolete** or non-functional? A significant **portion** of this electronic waste **is dumped** into landfills or gets thrown into informal recycling sectors that **employ** unsafe methods of **disposal**. This **leaches** toxic substances into the soil and water, causing **considerable ecological** and health risks. Shockingly, only 22 per cent of India's e-waste is properly recycled, while the rest contributes to pollution and resource wastage.

India has a chance to turn its waste crisis into an opportunity by adopting a circular economy. By concentrating on the repair, **refurbishment**, and recycling of electronic items, we can significantly decrease carbon **emissions**, **conserve** valuable resources, and even **stimulate** the economy. There are endless possibilities for businesses in recycling and remanufacturing, while even greater possibilities can open in job creation for waste management and eco-friendly innovations.

While global solutions are wider in scope, there is an opportunity to implement real change at a much more local level by involving the younger generation in this battle against e-waste.

The **ability** of youth to challenge the **status quo** and think creatively **is** key to turning the circular economy from concept to reality. By including youth in conversations about circular economy, we can encourage them to view waste as not an end goal, but a resource that can open up other **avenues**, if **explored**.

The Indian government has already taken several measures to **mitigate** the waste issue and to encourage circular practices. **Policies** such as the National Resource Efficiency Policy (NREP) **seek** to minimise wastes while maximising resources. The well-known Swachh Bharat Mission has not only improved **sanitation** but also **highlighted** the importance of responsible waste disposal.

Other **initiatives** such as the Atal Innovation Mission **aim** at getting the younger generation to think innovatively about meeting the **sustainability** challenge. Additionally, the Mission LiFE (Lifestyle for Environment) **campaign** launched by Prime Minister Modi at COP 26 in 2021 **endeavours** to **sensitise** different sections to **inculcate** green habits in their daily lives. With the **incorporation** of this policy along with regional effort, we can lay a stronger base for the circular economy in India.

Moving towards a circular economy **is** about securing India's future. However, most importantly, it's about **cultivating** a shift in mindset; from a culture of waste to a culture of value. **[Practice Exercise]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Sustainable** (adjective) – Eco-friendly, Renewable, Enduring, Viable, Maintainable
टिकाऊ
2. **Alarming** (adjective) – Disturbing, Worrying, Frightening, Shocking, Startling
चिंताजनक
3. **Lie** (verb) – Reside, Exist, Rest, Dwell, Be situated
निहित होना
4. **Manifold** (adjective) – Multiple, Numerous, Diverse, Varied, Multifaceted
विविध
5. **Unprecedented** (adjective) – Unparalleled, Unmatched, Unrivaled, Exceptional, Unique
अभूतपूर्व
6. **Obsolete** (adjective) – Outdated, Outmoded, Antiquated, Archaic, Defunct
अप्रचलित
7. **Dump** (verb) – Discard, Dispose, Abandon, Jettison, Scrap
फेंकना
8. **Employ** (verb) – Use, Utilize, Apply, Engage, Deploy
उपयोग करना
9. **Disposal** (noun) – Discarding, Removal, Elimination, Dumping, Junking
निपटान
10. **Leach** (verb) – Drain away from soil, ash, or similar material by the action of percolating liquid, especially rainwater.
रिसना
11. **Considerable** (adjective) – Significant, Substantial, Large, Notable, Sizable
काफी
12. **Ecological** (adjective) – Environmental, Green, Natural, Eco-friendly, Sustainable
पारिस्थितिक
13. **Refurbishment** (noun) – Renovation, Restoration, Repair, Renewal, Overhaul
मरम्मत
14. **Emission** (noun) – Discharge, Release, Ejection, Exhaust, Output
उत्सर्जन
15. **Conserve** (verb) – Preserve, Protect, Save, Sustain, Safeguard
संरक्षित करना
16. **Stimulate** (verb) – Encourage, Boost, Spur, Promote, Activate
प्रोत्साहित करना
17. **Status quo** (noun) – Existing condition, Current situation, Present state, Norm, Routine
यथास्थिति
18. **Avenue** (noun) – Path, Route, Opportunity, Channel, Means
मार्ग
19. **Explore** (verb) – Investigate, Examine, Research, Probe, Analyze
खोजना
20. **Mitigate** (verb) – Reduce, Alleviate, Lessen, Diminish, Ease
कम करना
21. **Sanitation** (noun) – Hygiene, Cleanliness, Public health, Waste management, Purity
स्वच्छता

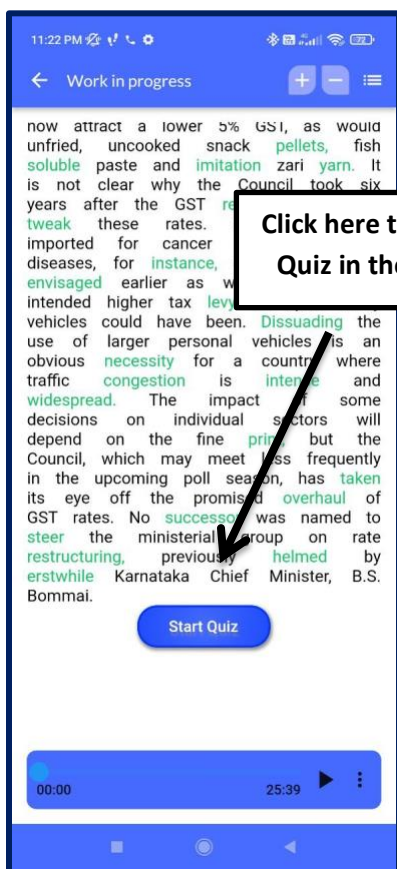
22. **Highlight** (verb) – Emphasize, Spotlight, Underscore, Accentuate, Feature जोर देना
23. **Sustainability** (noun) – Durability, Endurance, Viability, Longevity, Maintenance सततता
24. **Endeavour** (verb) – Strive, Attempt, Try, Aim, Seek प्रयास करना
25. **Sensitise** (verb) – Educate, Inform, Raise awareness, Familiarize, Enlighten जागरूक करना
26. **Inculcate** (verb) – Instill, Implant, Impart, Teach, Indoctrinate मन में बैठाना
27. **Incorporation** (noun) – Integration, Inclusion, Addition, Assimilation, Merging समावेश
28. **Cultivate** (verb) – Nurture, Develop, Foster, Promote, Encourage विकसित करना

@mocks_wallah

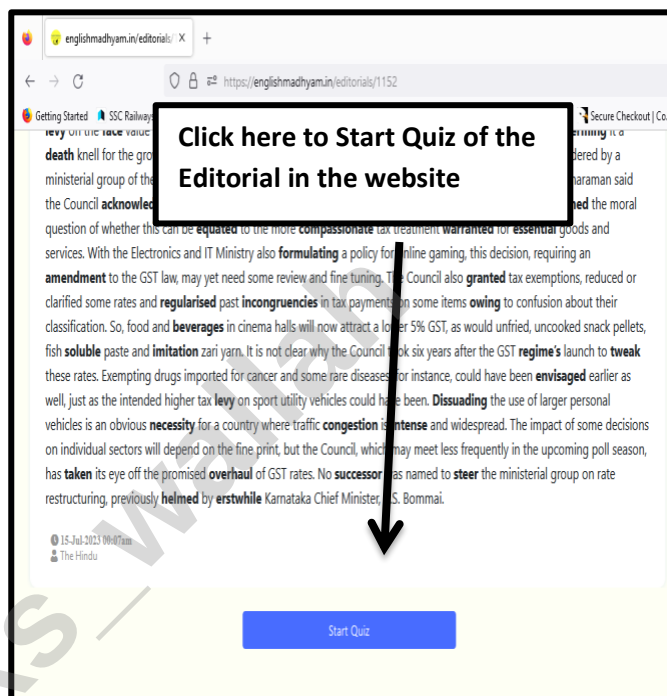
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Global Waste Crisis:** The world produces approximately 2.01 billion tonnes of waste annually, and India is a significant contributor to this crisis.
2. **E-Waste in India:** India is the third-largest producer of e-waste globally, generating 1.751 million metric tonnes in 2023-24, a 72.54% increase from 2019-20.
3. **Circular Economy Solution:** A circular economy, focused on reusing, recycling, and repurposing materials, is a sustainable solution to India's e-waste problem.
4. **Benefits of Circular Economy:** It can reduce pollution, create jobs, and build a healthier, sustainable future.
5. **Current E-Waste Disposal:** Most e-waste is dumped in landfills or processed unsafely in informal sectors, leading to soil and water contamination.
6. **Low Recycling Rates:** Only 22% of India's e-waste is properly recycled, with the rest contributing to pollution and resource wastage.
7. **Economic Opportunities:** Adopting a circular economy can stimulate the economy through recycling, remanufacturing, and job creation in waste management.
8. **Environmental Benefits:** Repairing, refurbishing, and recycling electronics can reduce carbon emissions and conserve resources.
9. **Youth Involvement:** Engaging the younger generation is crucial for driving innovation and turning the circular economy concept into reality.
10. **Government Initiatives:** Policies like the National Resource Efficiency Policy (NREP) and Swachh Bharat Mission promote waste reduction and responsible disposal.
11. **Innovation and Sustainability:** Programs like the Atal Innovation Mission encourage innovative thinking to address sustainability challenges.
12. **Mission LIFE:** Launched at COP 26, this campaign aims to promote green habits and environmental awareness among citizens.
13. **Local-Level Change:** Real change can be achieved by implementing circular economy practices at the local level with community involvement.
14. **Mindset Shift:** Transitioning to a circular economy requires a cultural shift from a "use and throw" mindset to valuing waste as a resource.
15. **Securing India's Future:** A circular economy is essential for India's sustainable development and long-term environmental health.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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